We challenge this conventional wisdom by exploring how ideologically driven detractors actively work to undermine IOs from within, reshaping these institutions in profound ways. Far from being passive arenas for state cooperation, IOs are dynamic entities that must grapple with existential threats, including the populist wave that has swept across global politics in recent decades. By highlighting this often-neglected aspect, we contribute to ongoing debates about how political contestation shapes and reshapes organizations (Streeck and Thelen 2005).

Further, our work moves beyond the traditional focus on major geopolitical shifts as drivers of multilateral change (Wallander 2000; Ikenberry 2001). Instead, we examine how continual, incremental political shifts—such as the rise of populist leaders—can fundamentally alter the international environment and the functioning of IOs. We demonstrate that these smaller, persistent pressures are highly consequential in reshaping global governance. In doing so, we extend the literature on how political incentives influence multilateral policymaking (Barnett and Finnemore 1999; Stone 2011; Clark and Dolan 2021), offering new insights into the mechanisms by which IOs adapt, resist, and survive.

While scholars have documented populists' hostility toward IOs and their efforts to dismantle these institutions (Copelovitch and Pevehouse 2019; Voeten 2020, 2021), much of this work portrays IOs as helpless in the face of such challenges. As Dijkstra et al. (2022) note, we are only beginning to understand how IOs respond to existential threats, making this study a timely and necessary contribution to the field. Our research identifies and tests the specific strategies IOs use to defend themselves against the populist onslaught. These strategies range from appeasing populist leaders to sidelining them and engaging directly with their domestic constituents. By exploring these tactics, we offer a more nuanced understanding of how IOs preserve their relevance and authority in an era of mounting challenges.

This book also addresses broader questions about the resilience of IOs and the future of global governance. As populism challenges the foundational principles of the liberal order, IOs are not mere bystanders; they actively resist and adapt to these pressures. However, this resistance comes with trade-offs, raising questions about transparency, legitimacy, and the long-term stability of the international system.